THE EASE OF LIVING

Simply having a public health insurance scheme does not necessarily mean easier access to healthcare. That is why the AB PM-JAY scheme does more than provide health coverage of up to Rs 5 lakh per family a year for secondary and tertiary care hospitalisation. Firstly, the scheme covers a wide variety of medical services—over 1,500 medical packages, including hospitalisation, surgeries, diagnostics as well as pre- and post-hospitalisation costs. It also covers 1,949 medical procedures across 27 medical specialties, such as general medicine, surgery, oncology and cardiology. Not only can beneficiaries claim money against treatment costs, they can also get free drugs (including 15 days of post-discharge medication), diagnostics (up to three days before admission), food and lodging at no cost.

Then there is the ease of use. "It was completely cashless. I didn't have to pay a single paisa from my own pocket. I just showed my card and my cancer treatment was taken care of," says Priyam Kumari, 39, a domestic help from Delhi who availed herself of the scheme during her breast cancer treatment at AIIMS Delhi. Furthermore, AB PM-JAY has empanelled 30,529 hospitals across the country, with 17,063 public and 13,466 private hospitals, and beneficiaries can get treated at any of them, irrespective of where they stay. And, unlike many private insurance schemes, AB PM-JAY offers coverage from the very first day of enrolment. Also, all pre-existing medical conditions are covered, ensuring timely treatment.

Since its implementation, out-of-pocket expenses have fallen by 21 per cent; loans for health expenses have decreased by 8 per cent

"AB PM-JAY is the world's largest publicly funded health assurance scheme. Last year onwards, all senior citizens aged 70 or above are also eligible for free medical treatment up to Rs 5 lakh a year," says V.K. Paul, member, NITI Aayog, and a public health expert. Senior citizens covered by other public health insurance schemes or private health insurance policies can also benefit from AB PM-JAY.

The scheme has achieved wide success. So far, it has cleared 77.9 million hospital admissions, providing Rs 1.07 lakh crore in financial coverage. Notably, 2.2 million cataract surgeries worth Rs 1,692 crore; 561,000 breast cancer treatments worth Rs 808 crore and 471,000 heart angioplasties worth Rs 4,653 crore have been covered.

According to the Union ministry of health and family welfare (MoHFW), AB PM-JAY has led to savings of over Rs 1.25 lakh crore in out-of-pocket expenses. Since its implementation, there has been a 21 per cent reduction in out-of-pocket healthcare expenditure and an 8 per cent decrease in loans taken for health-related expenses.

District hospitals, too, have experienced substantial financial gains, with an annual net benefit of Rs 226 crore. Projections by MoHFW suggest that potential growth could increase this figure to Rs 362 crore. AB PM-JAY has, no doubt, been a game-changer, not just in its ease of use but also the variety of coverage, changing millions of lives for the better. ■



HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"Ayushman Bharat is the reason my husband is alive"

For Champa Devi and her husband Gurudin, the Ayushman Bharat scheme has come as a blessing, sparing them the worry over big healthcare expenses. The first time Champa used her Ayushman card was for an eye surgery at a hospital in Ayodhya. "There were no problems and all I needed to provide were my fingerprints. Someone was there to guide us through the process and we got quick, safe care," she says.

Then, in May 2024, Gurudin was grievously injured in a car accident and was close to death. Ayushman Bharat helped save his life as most of his treatment was covered under the insurance scheme. The ageing couple did have to pay some money, but it was negligible compared to what they would have had to pay if they had no insurance. "Ayushman Bharat is the reason I have good vision and my husband is alive today," admits Champa. ■

CHAMPA DEVI, 70, GURUDIN PANDEY, 71
Nawabganj, Uttar Pradesh